

# Three Tests *in the Wilderness*

*Bread, a leap, a kingdom, and three times: "It is written."*

▶ Watch on YouTube | Read Matthew 4:1-11 in the LSB | 18:04 | Channel: Every Word

Full title: The Hidden Battle Between Jesus and Satan That Most MISS! (Matthew 4:1-11). Series: The Gospel of Matthew Every Word (playlist of 58 videos).

FROM THE VIDEO · BACKGROUND (ADDED) · DEBATED · LSB TEXT · ◆ LOGOS FACTBOOK LINK

01 · FROM THE VIDEO

## Short summary

- The teacher reads Matthew 4:1-11: the Spirit leads Jesus into the wilderness, He fasts forty days and nights, and the tempter tests Him three times. Each time Jesus answers, 'It is written,' quoting Deuteronomy. Then the devil leaves and angels minister to Him.
- Three tests, three expressions of one idea: what it means to be the Son of God. Food (appetite), rescue at the temple (affirmation from the Father), and the kingdoms of the world (power and ambition).
- The temptation is the culmination of a thread Matthew has woven since chapter 1: Jesus linked to Abraham, a Pharaoh-like Herod, a child hidden in Egypt, a baptism 'to fulfill all righteousness,' and the Father's voice, 'This is My beloved Son,' just as God called Israel His son.
- Like Israel, Jesus is led into the wilderness (the cloud and fire, Exodus 13:21), is hungry, and is tested. His answer about testing God points back to Massah, where Israel asked, 'Is Yahweh among us or not?' (Exodus 17:7).
- Behind it all is desire: Israel 'asking for food according to their desire' (Psalm 78:18) and Eve seeing that the tree was 'good for food' (Genesis 3:6). Where Adam, Eve and Israel gave in, Jesus, standing in Israel's place, says no.
- The lesson for the first hearers and for us: God's people need to be so filled and satisfied with the word of God

> *"The first time Jesus is tempted with food, the second time Jesus is tempted with rescue, and the third time with power."*
>
> From the video (auto-captions, lightly cleaned)

> *"Jesus' temptation in the wilderness is the culmination of a thematic thread that Matthew has been weaving from the very start of his gospel."*
>
> From the video (auto-captions, lightly cleaned)

that they stand firm in trusting Him, even in temptation. Like the Creator who rested, we learn to know when enough is enough.



*'Command that these stones become bread' (4:3)*

James Tissot, Jesus Tempted in the Wilderness, 1886-1894. Brooklyn Museum via Wikimedia Commons, public domain



*On the pinnacle of the temple (4:5)*

James Tissot, Jesus Carried up to a Pinnacle of the Temple, 1886-1894. Brooklyn Museum via Wikimedia Commons, public domain

### Read it as the first hearers did

Matthew's first hearers knew the Exodus story and the garden of Genesis 3 by heart, and they probably heard this Gospel read aloud in church. So the teacher asks one question of verses 1-11: by telling this story, what is Matthew teaching the reader about Jesus? Listen for Israel's wilderness and Eden's garden behind every line.

The video reads from another English translation. Quotations on this page are from the LSB.

02 · FROM THE VIDEO · LSB TEXT

## Scripture passages covered

Each link opens those verses on read.lsbible.org.

Matthew 4:1-11

Matthew 3:13-17

The Spirit leads Jesus into the wilderness; three temptations, three answers from Deuteronomy; angels minister to Him.

Context: 'Then' (4:1) follows straight on from the baptism and the Father's voice, 'This is My beloved Son.'

### Mark 1:12-13

Mark's short account: forty days, Satan, the wild beasts, and angels ministering.

### Luke 4:1-13

Luke's account: the second and third tests come in the opposite order, ending at Jerusalem.

### Deuteronomy 8:1-5

Source of the first answer (8:3): forty years of testing, hunger and manna, 'as a man disciplines his son.'

### Deuteronomy 6:10-16

Source of the second and third answers (6:13, 16), right after the Shema (6:4-5).

### Psalm 91

The psalm the devil quotes (91:11-12). Read on to 91:13.

### Exodus 17:1-7

Massah and Meribah: Israel tests Yahweh, 'Is Yahweh among us or not?' The video reads 17:7.

### Psalm 78:17-19

The video's reading: Israel put God to the test 'by asking for food according to their desire.'

### Genesis 3:1-7

The serpent in the garden; the video reads 3:6, Eve sees the tree was good for food and a delight to the eyes.

### Exodus 13:21-22

The video reads 13:21: Yahweh led Israel by the pillar of cloud and fire.

### Matthew 4:12-17

Coming next (Episode 5): Jesus moves to Capernaum, fulfilling Isaiah 9:1-2.

## Key verses in the LSB

> “Then Jesus was led up by the Spirit into the wilderness to be tempted by the devil.”
>
> Matthew 4:1 (LSB)

> “It is written, ‘Man shall not live on bread alone, but on every word that proceeds out of the mouth of God.’”
>
> Matthew 4:4 (LSB)

> “Go, Satan! For it is written, ‘You shall worship the Lord your God, and serve Him only.’”
>
> Matthew 4:10 (LSB)

> “Then the devil left Him; and behold, angels came and began to minister to Him.”
>
> Matthew 4:11 (LSB)

# Three tests, three answers

Food, rescue, power. Each card stamps 'It is written' as you scroll: the tempter's offer, Jesus' answer, and the Deuteronomy verse He quotes, all in the LSB.



TEST 1 · APPETITE

## Stones into bread

THE TEMPTER · MATTHEW 4:3

“If You are the Son of God, command that these stones become bread.”

JESUS · MATTHEW 4:4

“It is written, ‘Man shall not live on bread alone, but on every word that proceeds out of the mouth of God.’”

DEUTERONOMY 8:3 (LSB)

IT IS WRITTEN

“And He humbled you and let you be hungry and fed you with manna which you did not know, nor did your fathers know, that He might make you know that man does not live by bread alone, but by everything that proceeds out of the mouth of Yahweh.”

ISRAEL IN THE WILDERNESS Yahweh let Israel be hungry and fed them manna, 'testing you, to know what was in your heart' (Deuteronomy 8:2-3). Later they 'put God to the test by asking for food according to their desire' (Psalm 78:18). Deuteronomy 8:2-3 Psalm 78:17-19

The video: Satan tempts Jesus to use His 'son-of-God-ness' to eat. Jesus is truly hungry (4:2) and still trusts His Father to feed Him.



TEST 2 · AFFIRMATION

## A leap from the temple

THE TEMPTER · MATTHEW 4:6

“If You are the Son of God, throw Yourself down; for it is written, / ‘He will command His angels concerning You’; and / ‘On their hands they will bear You up, / Lest You strike Your foot against a stone.’”

JESUS · MATTHEW 4:7

“Again, it is written, ‘You shall not put the Lord your God to the test.’”

DEUTERONOMY 6:16 (LSB)

IT IS WRITTEN

“You shall not put Yahweh your God to the test, as you tested Him at Massah.”

PSALM IN CONTEXT The devil quotes Psalm 91:11-12. The next line reads: 'You will tread upon the fierce lion and cobra, / The young lion and the serpent you will trample down' (91:13).

ISRAEL IN THE WILDERNESS At Massah Israel 'tested Yahweh, saying, “Is Yahweh among us or not?”' (Exodus 17:7). The video: with the Father not visibly present, Satan invites Jesus to force Him to show up. Exodus 17:1-7 Psalm 91:11-13

Jesus will not stage a test to prove the Father is with Him. Later He says He could appeal to His Father for 'more than twelve legions of angels' (Matthew 26:53), and still chooses the cross.



TEST 3 · AMBITION

## All the kingdoms of the world

THE TEMPTER · MATTHEW 4:9

“All these things I will give You, if You fall down and worship me.”

JESUS · MATTHEW 4:10

“Go, Satan! For it is written, ‘You shall worship the Lord your God, and serve Him only.’”

📜 DEUTERONOMY 6:13 (LSB)

IT IS WRITTEN

“Yahweh your God you shall fear; and Him you shall serve; and by His name you shall swear.”

ISRAEL IN THE WILDERNESS The next verse warns, 'You shall not walk after other gods' (Deuteronomy 6:14). At Sinai Israel 'made for themselves a molten calf and have worshiped it' (Exodus 32:8). Deuteronomy 6:13-15 Exodus 32:1-8

Matthew's wording ('worship... Him only') follows the Greek Old Testament tradition rather than the Hebrew 'fear.' The kingdoms Satan offers, Jesus receives later from the Father by way of the cross: 'All authority has been given to Me in heaven and on earth' (28:18).

## Back to the garden: the same desires

“Then the woman saw that the tree was good for food, and that it was a delight to the eyes, and that the tree was desirable to make one wise, so she took from its fruit and ate; and she gave also to her husband with her, and he ate.”

Genesis 3:6

VIDEO The teacher reads Genesis 3:6 and tracks the language of desire. Eve gave in, Israel gave in, all of us have given in; Jesus, the faithful Son, did not.

DEBATED Some readers also line up the three tests with 'the lust of the flesh and the lust of the eyes and the boastful pride of life' (1 John 2:16) or with the three phrases of Genesis 3:6. The parallel is suggestive; a one-to-one match is debated. Paul draws the larger contrast: 'through the one man’s disobedience the many were appointed sinners, even so through the obedience of the One the many will be appointed righteous' (Romans 5:19).

Genesis 3:1-7 1 John 2:16 Romans 5:19



*'All these things I will give You' (4:9)*

Duccio di Buoninsegna, The Temptation of Christ on the Mountain, 1308-1311. Frick Collection, New York, via Wikimedia Commons, public domain



*Angels came and began to minister to Him (4:11)*

James Tissot, Jesus Ministered to by Angels, 1886-1894. Brooklyn Museum via Wikimedia Commons, public domain

> *"Eve succumbed to her desires. Israel succumbed to their desires... Jesus, standing in the place of Israel as the suffering, chosen servant of Yahweh, goes through the same experiences, but this time He denies those desires.*
>
> From the video, on why this scene matters

04 · FROM THE VIDEO

# Israel then, Jesus now

The teacher's thread: Jesus stands in Israel's place and walks Israel's road, but this time the Son is faithful. Rows marked Added go beyond the video.

| | |
|---|---|
| THEN · EXODUS 4:22<br>'Israel is My son, My firstborn.' | → NOW · MATTHEW 3:17; 4:3<br>The Father: 'This is My beloved Son' (3:17). The tempter: 'If You are the Son of God' (4:3, 6). |
| THEN · EXODUS 13:21<br>'Yahweh was going before them in a pillar of cloud by day to guide them on the way.' | → NOW · MATTHEW 4:1<br>'Jesus was led up by the Spirit into the wilderness.' |
| THEN · DEUTERONOMY 8:2<br>'Yahweh your God has led you in the wilderness these forty years... testing you.' | → NOW · MATTHEW 4:2 ADDED<br>'After He had fasted forty days and forty nights, He then became hungry.' |

| THEN | NOW |
| --- | --- |
| THEN · DEUTERONOMY 8:3<br>'He humbled you and let you be hungry and fed you with manna.' | NOW · MATTHEW 4:3-4<br>Hungry, Jesus refuses to make bread for Himself and quotes this very verse. |
| THEN · EXODUS 17:7<br>Israel 'tested Yahweh, saying, “Is Yahweh among us or not?”' | NOW · MATTHEW 4:7<br>'You shall not put the Lord your God to the test.' |
| THEN · PSALM 78:18<br>'They put God to the test / By asking for food according to their desire.' | NOW · MATTHEW 4:1-11<br>Jesus denies His desires and trusts His Father. |
| THEN · DEUTERONOMY 34:1-4<br>From Mount Nebo, 'Yahweh showed him all the land' that Israel would receive. | NOW · MATTHEW 4:8 ADDED<br>The devil 'showed Him all the kingdoms of the world and their glory.' |
| THEN · EXODUS 32:8<br>Israel 'made for themselves a molten calf and have worshiped it.' | NOW · MATTHEW 4:10 ADDED<br>'You shall worship the Lord your God, and serve Him only.' |

> *“Jesus' temptation in the wilderness is the culmination of a thematic thread that Matthew has been weaving from the very start of his gospel.*
>
> From the video

05

# Who's who in the wilderness

What the video says, then a short background note.

## Jesus

VIDEO The beloved Son standing in the place of Israel, Yahweh's chosen servant. Where Adam, Eve and Israel gave in to desire, He refuses, answering each test with Scripture.

BACKGROUND 'One who has been tempted in all things like we are, yet without sin' (Hebrews 4:15). 'He is able to come to help those who are tempted' (Hebrews 2:18).

Hebrews 4:14-16 · Hebrews 2:17-18 · ◆ Jesus Christ · ◆ Temptation of Jesus · ◆ God the Son

## The devil, the tempter, Satan

VIDEO He strikes three times at one idea: what it means to be the Son of God.

BACKGROUND Matthew uses three names: 'the devil' (4:1, Greek diabolos), 'the tempter' (4:3) and 'Satan' (4:10, from Hebrew satan, 'adversary'). In the Old Testament the satan appears as an accuser in Job 1-2 and Zechariah 3. Luke adds that he left Jesus 'until an opportune time' (Luke 4:13).

Job 1:6-12 · Zechariah 3:1-2 · Luke 4:13 · ◆ Satan

### The Spirit

VIDEO Leads Jesus into the wilderness, as the cloud and fire led Israel.

BACKGROUND Mark is stronger: 'the Spirit drove Him to go out into the wilderness' (Mark 1:12). Luke: Jesus was 'full of the Holy Spirit' (Luke 4:1). The same Spirit came down on Him at His baptism (3:16).

Mark 1:12 · Luke 4:1 · Matthew 3:16 · ◆ Holy Spirit

### Angels

VIDEO After the devil leaves, 'angels came and began to minister to Him' (4:11).

BACKGROUND The verb (diakoneō) is also used for waiting on someone at a meal (8:15). Jesus would not force Psalm 91's angels to catch Him; afterward His Father sends them. Mark adds that 'He was with the wild beasts' (Mark 1:13).

Matthew 4:11 · Matthew 8:15 · Mark 1:13 · ◆ Angel

### Israel in the wilderness

VIDEO God's son, led by the cloud, tested by hunger, and failing by desire (Exodus 13, 17; Psalm 78).

BACKGROUND Deuteronomy 8:5: 'Yahweh your God was disciplining you just as a man disciplines his son.' All three of Jesus' answers come from Moses' sermons to this generation (Deuteronomy 6-8).

Deuteronomy 8:1-5 · Psalm 78:17-19 · ◆ The Exodus · ◆ Wilderness · ◆ Manna · ◆ Pillar of cloud and fire

### Adam and Eve

VIDEO The first humans, enticed by the serpent and led by desire (Genesis 3:6).

BACKGROUND Irenaeus (2nd century) reads the temptation as Jesus 're-running' Adam's test and winning it (see Early witnesses). Paul contrasts 'the one man's disobedience' with 'the obedience of the One' (Romans 5:19).

Genesis 3:1-7 · Romans 5:12-19 · ◆ Adam · ◆ Eve · ◆ Garden of Eden · ◆ The Fall

### Moses and Elijah

VIDEO The video compares the child Jesus, hidden from a murderous tyrant, to Moses. It does not mention their forty-day fasts.

BACKGROUND Moses was on the mountain 'forty days and forty nights; he did not eat bread or drink water' (Exodus 34:28). Elijah went 'forty days and forty nights to Horeb' (1 Kings 19:8). Both later appear with Jesus on the mountain (17:3).

Exodus 34:28 · 1 Kings 19:8 · Matthew 17:1-3 · ◆ Moses · ◆ Elijah (prophet) · ◆ Mount Sinai (Horeb)

06 · BACKGROUND

# From the Jordan to the wilderness

Teal pins are places the video names; gold pins are background. The shaded area is the wilderness of Judea. Routes are schematic.




● Named in the video ● Background ▬ Led by the Spirit into the wilderness (4:1) ▬ Taken to the holy city (4:5)

▬ Coming next: Nazareth to Capernaum (4:13)

Positions approximate. Coastlines, lakes and rivers: Natural Earth (public domain). Matthew names neither the spot in the wilderness nor the 'very high mountain.' Tribal areas of Zebulun and Naphtali are approximate.

### Jerusalem VIDEO

'The holy city': the devil sets Jesus on the pinnacle of the temple (4:5)

◆ Factbook: Jerusalem ◆ Factbook: Temple (Jewish)

### Bethany beyond the Jordan BACKGROUND

Where John was baptizing (John 1:28); Jesus comes up from the water just before (3:16)

◆ Factbook: Jordan River

### Jericho BACKGROUND

A later Christian tradition places the forty days and the 'very high mountain' on the cliffs just west of Jericho (the 'Mount of

### Nazareth BACKGROUND

Jesus' hometown; next He leaves it for Capernaum (4:13)

Temptation'). Matthew names no place.

◆ Factbook: Jericho

◆ Factbook: Mount of Temptation (Quarantania)

◆ Factbook: Nazareth

**Capernaum** BACKGROUND

'By the sea, in the region of Zebulun and Naphtali' (4:13). Next episode.

◆ Factbook: Capernaum

**Gadara** BACKGROUND

One of the Decapolis cities; crowds come 'from Galilee and the Decapolis' (4:25)

◆ Factbook: Decapolis

07

# Key terms

## Tempt / test

BACKGROUND

One Greek verb (peirazō) covers both. God tests to prove and strengthen (Deuteronomy 8:2); the devil tempts to make someone fall. 'God cannot be tempted by evil, and He Himself does not tempt anyone' (James 1:13).

◆ Factbook: Temptation of Jesus

## If You are the Son of God

VIDEO

The question behind all three tests. The Father has just said 'This is My beloved Son' (3:17); the tempter does not deny it but pushes Jesus to use His sonship for Himself. The same taunt returns at the cross: 'If You are the Son of God, come down from the cross' (27:40).

◆ Factbook: God the Son

## It is written

VIDEO

Jesus' answer three times. The Greek perfect tense means 'it stands written': settled and still in force. All three quotations come from Deuteronomy 6-8.

◆ Factbook: Book of Deuteronomy

## Forty days and forty nights

BACKGROUND

The video promises to return to numbers but does not. Forty marks testing and preparation: the flood (Genesis 7:12), Moses on the mountain (Exodus 34:28), Israel's forty years (Deuteronomy 8:2), Elijah (1 Kings 19:8).

◆ Factbook: Fasting

## The holy city

BACKGROUND

Jerusalem. Matthew uses the phrase again in 27:53.

◆ Factbook: Jerusalem

## Pinnacle of the temple

BACKGROUND

Literally 'little wing' (pterygion), some high edge of the temple complex. Matthew does not say which; many think of the southeast corner above the Kidron Valley.

◆ Factbook: Temple (Jewish)

### A very high mountain

BACKGROUND

Matthew names no mountain; no single peak shows 'all the kingdoms of the world.' Mountains matter in Matthew: the sermon (5:1), the transfiguration (17:1), the commission (28:16).

◆ Factbook: Mount of Temptation (Quarantania)

### Massah

VIDEO

'Testing,' the place where Israel quarreled and asked, 'Is Yahweh among us or not?' (Exodus 17:7). Deuteronomy 6:16, which Jesus quotes, names it.

◆ Factbook: Meribah

### Desire

VIDEO

The video's key word. Eve saw the tree was 'desirable' (Genesis 3:6); Israel asked for food 'according to their desire' (Psalm 78:18). 'Each one is tempted when he is carried away and enticed by his own lust' (James 1:14).

◆ Factbook: The Fall

08 · BACKGROUND

## Hebrew and Greek words

Strong's numbers match the LSB's own word tagging for the verses listed. Glosses summarize the standard lexicons; 'Look up' points you to the entry to read for yourself (BDAG for Greek; BDB or HALOT for Hebrew).

### πειράζω

***peirazō*** G3985

To test, try; to tempt. The same verb gives 'to be tempted' (4:1) and 'the tempter' (4:3, ho peirazōn, 'the one testing'). Context decides between testing and tempting. Look up: BDAG, πειράζω.

Greek · Matt 4:1, 3

◆ Factbook: Temptation of Jesus

### ἐκπειράζω

***ekpeirazō*** G1598

To put to the test. A strengthened form of peirazō, used in the Greek Old Testament of Deuteronomy 6:16 and quoted here. Look up: BDAG, ἐκπειράζω.

Greek · Matt 4:7

### διάβολος

***diabolos*** G1228

As an adjective 'slanderous'; as a noun 'slanderer,' and in the New Testament 'the devil.' Look up: BDAG,

### Σατανᾶς

***Satanas*** G4567

Satan, the Greek form of Hebrew satan, 'adversary.' Jesus' 'Go' (hypage) here is the same word as 'Get

διάβολος.

Greek · Matt 4:1, 5, 8, 11

◆ Factbook: Satan

behind Me, Satan!' to Peter (16:23).

Greek · Matt 4:10; 16:23

◆ Factbook: Satan

## πτερύγιον

***pterygion*** `G4419`

Diminutive of pteryx, 'wing': a tip or edge, here a high point of the temple. Which spot is meant is uncertain. Look up: BDAG, πτερύγιον.

Greek · Matt 4:5

◆ Factbook: Temple (Jewish)

## προσκυνέω

***proskyneō*** `G4352`

To bow down, prostrate oneself; to worship. The magi came to 'worship' Jesus (2:2, 11); Satan asks Jesus to 'fall down and worship' him.

Greek · Matt 4:9, 10; 2:2, 11

◆ Factbook: Worship

## λατρεύω

***latreuō*** `G3000`

To serve, especially in worship. Translates Hebrew 'abad' (serve) in Deuteronomy 6:13.

Greek · Matt 4:10

◆ Factbook: Worship

## διακονέω

***diakoneō*** `G1247`

To serve, wait on, minister; used of serving at a meal. The angels 'began to minister' after His long hunger (4:11; compare 8:15).

Greek · Matt 4:11; 8:15

## ῥῆμα

***rhēma*** `G4487`

Word, saying, something spoken. 'Every word that proceeds out of the mouth of God' (4:4), the verse behind the channel's name.

Greek · Matt 4:4

## נָסָה

***nasah*** `H5254`

To test, try, prove. Used for God testing Israel (Deuteronomy 8:2) and Israel testing God (Exodus 17:7; Deuteronomy 6:16). Look up: BDB or HALOT, נסה.

Hebrew · Deut 6:16; 8:2; Exod 17:7

## מַסָּה

***massah*** `H4532`

'Testing,' a place name from nasah. Exodus 17:7 explains the name: 'because they tested Yahweh.'

Hebrew · Exod 17:7; Deut 6:16

◆ Factbook: Meribah

## מוֹצָא

***motsa*** `H4161`

That which goes out, an utterance. 'Everything that proceeds out of the mouth of Yahweh' (Deuteronomy 8:3). Look up: BDB or HALOT, מוֹצָא.

Hebrew · Deut 8:3

## עָבַד

***abad*** `H5647`

To work, serve; also to serve in worship. 'Him you shall serve' (Deuteronomy 6:13).

## שָׂטָן

***satan*** `H7854`

Adversary, accuser; with the article, 'the satan' (Job 1:6; Zechariah 3:1). Look up: BDB or HALOT, שָׂטָן.

Hebrew · Deut 6:13

◆ Factbook: Worship

Hebrew · Job 1:6; Zech 3:1

◆ Factbook: Satan

09

# Historical and cultural background

ESTABLISHED **Facts most interpreters agree on**

### All three answers: Deuteronomy 6-8

Deuteronomy is Moses' farewell preaching to Israel on the plains of Moab, after forty years in the wilderness. Jesus quotes 8:3, 6:16 and 6:13, close to the Shema: 'Hear, O Israel! Yahweh is our God, Yahweh is one! You shall love Yahweh your God with all your heart' (6:4-5). Matthew's wording follows the Greek Old Testament: 'every word' (8:3) and 'worship... Him only' (6:13).

### Three Gospels, one test

Mark gives two verses (1:12-13). Matthew and Luke give the three tests, but Luke has the temple last (Luke 4:5-12), while Matthew ends on the mountain, with worship. Matthew links the scene to the baptism: 'Then' (4:1).

### The temple Satan stood Him on

Herod the Great began rebuilding the temple and its courts in his eighteenth year, about 20/19 BC (Josephus, Antiquities 15.11.1). Josephus describes the royal portico on the south side as so high above the valley that anyone looking down would grow dizzy (Antiquities 15.11.5).

### Fasting forty days

Moses (Exodus 34:28; Deuteronomy 9:9) and Elijah (1 Kings 19:8) both went forty days without ordinary food. Matthew says Jesus 'fasted' (4:2); Luke says 'He ate nothing during those days' (Luke 4:2). Only afterward did He become hungry.

### Psalm 91 in context

A psalm of trust: whoever shelters in the Most High is guarded by His angels. The devil quotes 91:11-12 as a dare. The psalm's promise is for those who trust God, not for those who test Him.

SOURCED **Early witnesses**

> *"For as at the beginning it was by means of food that [the enemy] persuaded man, although not suffering hunger, to transgress God's commandments, so in the end he did not succeed in persuading Him that was an hungered to take that food which proceeded from God.*

Irenaeus of Lyons, c. AD 180. Against Heresies 5.21.2, Ante-Nicene Fathers vol. 1 (public domain). Of the second test he writes that the devil was 'concealing a falsehood under the guise of Scripture.'

> *"Then. When? After the descent of the Spirit, after the voice that was borne from above, and said, This is My Beloved Son, in whom I am well pleased.*
>
> John Chrysostom, c. AD 390. Homilies on Matthew 13, Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers, series 1, vol. 10 (public domain). He also says Jesus answered 'bringing him a testimony out of the ancient Scripture.'

DEBATED

## Where scholars differ

### Matthew's order or Luke's?

Luke has the temple last; Matthew has the mountain last. Many think Matthew's order builds to the climax of worship ('Go, Satan!'), while Luke's ends at Jerusalem, the goal of his Gospel. Neither writer says his order is chronological.

### Physical journey or vision?

No mountain shows 'all the kingdoms of the world,' so some read the second and third tests as visionary. Others take the journeys as real, with the 'showing' supernatural. Matthew says the devil 'took Him' (4:5, 8) and does not explain how.

### Could Jesus have sinned?

Hebrews says He was tempted 'in all things like we are, yet without sin' (4:15). Theologians differ on whether He was able not to sin or not able to sin; all agree the testing was real. The video puts it simply: 'Jesus is the God-man, and there are things only He could go through.'

### Do the three tests match Genesis 3:6 or 1 John 2:16?

Some line up food, eyes and pride one for one; others think that is too neat. The video links them more loosely, through the language of desire.

CAREFUL READING

## Small slips in the video

Small slips worth knowing (offered gently; the video's main points stand):

- The video says Herod 'killed firstborns.' Matthew 2:16 says he killed 'all the male children who were in Bethlehem and all its vicinity, from two years old and under.' Pharaoh had ordered every Hebrew son killed (Exodus 1:22); the death of the firstborn was the tenth plague, on Egypt (Exodus 12:29). The Pharaoh parallel still holds.
- The video promises, 'We're going to get into numbers and what they mean later,' but does not come back to the forty days. See Key terms and the Timeline for a start.
- The video calls Matthew 'probably a letter that's being read to the church.' Matthew is a Gospel, not a letter, though the teacher's point stands: it was likely heard read aloud by early believers.
- Among the Isaiah references, the video lists 'the true vine' (John 15:1). The words are Jesus' own in John; the Old Testament picture behind them is Israel as God's vine (Psalm 80:8; Isaiah 5:1-7).

- The captions read 'Matthew 4:1-1'; the passage is Matthew 4:1-11.

10 · BACKGROUND

# Forty days, forty years

Coral dots mark what Matthew 4:1-11 quotes or echoes. Early dates are approximate; dates tagged debated vary among scholars.

THE BEGINNING
**The serpent tempts Eve; desire leads to the first sin**
Genesis 3 *Echo: the test of desire*

PRIMEVAL HISTORY
**Rain for forty days and forty nights**
Genesis 7:12

C. 1446 OR 1260S BC DEBATED
**Israel, God's son, leaves Egypt led by cloud and fire; tests Yahweh at Massah**
Exodus 13-17 *Echo: 4:1, 7*

AT SINAI
**Moses on the mountain forty days and nights without bread; the golden calf below**
Exodus 32-34 *Echo: 4:2, 10*

END OF THE FORTY YEARS
**Moses preaches Deuteronomy on the plains of Moab; views the land from Mount Nebo**
Deuteronomy 6-8; 34 *Quoted: 4:4, 7, 10*

9TH CENTURY BC
**Elijah goes forty days and nights to Horeb**
1 Kings 19:8

C. 20/19 BC
**Herod the Great begins rebuilding the temple**
Matthew 4:5

C. AD 27-29 DEBATED
**Jesus is baptized, then tested forty days in the wilderness**
Matthew 3:13-4:11 *This episode*

AD 30 OR 33 DEBATED
**After His resurrection, Jesus appears to the apostles over forty days**
Acts 1:3

11

# Cross-references

Added cross-references for further study.

Mark 1:12-13; Luke 4:1-13

Deuteronomy 8:2-5

Parallel accounts

ADDED

Forty years of testing; man does not live by bread alone (for 4:2-4)

ADDED

Deuteronomy 6:13-16

Worship and serve Yahweh; do not test Him (for 4:7, 10)

ADDED

Psalm 91:11-13

The psalm the devil quotes, with the next verse (for 4:6)

ADDED

Exodus 17:1-7

Massah: 'Is Yahweh among us or not?' (for 4:7)

ADDED

Exodus 4:22; Deuteronomy 8:5

Israel as God's son (for 4:3, 6)

ADDED

Exodus 34:28; 1 Kings 19:8

Moses and Elijah: forty days (for 4:2)

ADDED

Genesis 3:1-7; Romans 5:19

Adam's failure and Christ's obedience

ADDED

Hebrews 2:18; 4:15

Tempted like us, yet without sin; able to help

ADDED

1 Corinthians 10:13

God provides the way of escape

ADDED

James 1:13-14

God tempts no one; desire entices

ADDED

Ephesians 6:17; Psalm 119:11

The word of God as the sword of the Spirit, treasured in the heart

ADDED

Matthew 16:23; 26:53; 27:40

The same temptations return on the road to the cross

ADDED

Isaiah 9:1-2; Matthew 4:14-16

Coming next: light for Zebulun and Naphtali

ADDED

12

# Reflection and discussion

0 of 4 questions marked done on this device.

1 ☐ The video's own challenge: 'If God's people need to be so filled and satisfied with the word of God that they can stand firm in trusting Him even in the midst of temptation, then will you?' What would that look like for you this week?

2 ☐ All three of Jesus' answers come from Deuteronomy 6-8. Read those three chapters. What else there would have strengthened Him, and you?

3 ☐ Appetite, affirmation, ambition: which of the three hits closest to home? Where do you need to tell a desire, 'No, I will not be ruled by you'?

4 ☐ The devil quoted Scripture too (Psalm 91). How can you tell Scripture used rightly from Scripture twisted? Read Psalm 91 whole and compare.

13

# Application

FROM THE VIDEO

The video's lesson for the original audience: to withstand the devil, who entices God's people to give in to their own desires, we must be filled with the word of God and so satisfied with it that we stand firm in trusting the Lord, His provision and His plans. Where mankind failed, Jesus succeeded. Like our Creator, who stopped and saw that His work was good, we learn to know when enough is enough. The lesson for you: will you be filled and satisfied with the word of God?

STUDY NOTE (ADDED)

Jesus did not invent new weapons; He used verses Israel had known for centuries, in context. Treasure the word now, before the test comes: 'Your word I have treasured in my heart, / That I may not sin against You' (Psalm 119:11). 'The sword of the Spirit... is the word of God' (Ephesians 6:17). And when you fail, the One who passed the test is 'able to come to help those who are tempted' (Hebrews 2:18; see 1 Corinthians 10:13).

> *"God's people need to be so filled and satisfied with the word of God that they can stand firm in trusting Him, even in the midst of temptation.*
>
> From the video

14

# Look it up in Logos

Each link opens that person, place or topic in the Logos Factbook, inside the Logos app on iPad, Mac or PC. The same links are in Copy all notes.

◆ Jesus Christ ◆ God the Son ◆ Temptation of Jesus ◆ Satan ◆ Holy Spirit ◆ Angel ◆ Moses ◆ Elijah (prophet) ◆ Adam ◆ Eve ◆ Serpent ◆ Garden of Eden ◆ The Fall ◆ The Exodus ◆ Wilderness ◆ Pillar of cloud and fire ◆ Manna ◆ Meribah ◆ Mount Sinai (Horeb) ◆ Golden calf ◆ Mount Nebo ◆ Book of Deuteronomy ◆ Shema ◆ Book of Psalms ◆ Fasting ◆ Worship ◆ Jerusalem ◆ Temple (Jewish) ◆ Jericho ◆ Mount of Temptation (Quarantania) ◆ Jordan River

◆ Nazareth ◆ Galilee ◆ Capernaum ◆ Tribe of Zebulun ◆ Territory of Naphtali ◆ Decapolis ◆ Isaiah ◆ Abraham ◆ Herod the Great ◆ Egypt ◆ Baptism of Jesus ◆ Irenaeus of Lyons ◆ John Chrysostom

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